FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The India Today Best Colleges Survey has kept up its standing as the country's most credible, dependable and exhaustive ranking of institutions of higher learning for over a quarter century. We offer you the 2023 edition—the 27th overall—at a time of intense transitions in education. There is today an urgent need for educational institutions to adapt to the rapidly changing world of human knowledge. For instance, artificial intelligence is creating new paradigms in every field of endeavour. Institutions have to pay heed to the new demands of the marketplace of jobs. Indian colleges have a wide range in the quality of education and facilities they offer. The good news is, there is a constant effort towards improvement as the demand for quality education continues to grow exponentially. Undoubtedly, the sheer number of Indians who go on to rub shoulders with the global knowledge elite testifies to that fact. If our survey of that field has remained the must-have hand guide for students and pedagogues alike, it's because of our annually honed criteria of judgement and the sensitivity of our barometer in gauging the currents of change. Conducted by a reputable market research agency, Marketing and Development Research Associates (MDRA), its reign at the top is confirmed by the steep rise in the number of participating colleges. It has nearly doubled in the last five years—from 988 in 2018 to 1,715 this year—reflecting a penetration into the smaller towns. And so the Indian Institute of Technology, Gandhinagar, makes an appearance among the top 10 government engineering colleges this year. The department of communication, University of Hyderabad, makes an entry at No. 5 in the top 10 league in Mass Communication. Elsewhere, the Jawaharlal Nehru Institute of Postgraduate Medical Education and Research moves up from No. 4 to No. 2 among top medical institutes. The higher turnout from hitherto-unheralded zones speaks of a salutary levelling out of the playing field in terms of access. Given our common national objective to pull our weight in the world, the beginnings are auspicious.



July 4, 2022

The other crucial aspect of change is entirely internal to India. We are in the throes of reimagining the very concept of higher learning—of restructuring the whole edifice and its scaffolding. Last year, the University Grants Commission introduced the Common University Entrance Test (CUET). This was a radical change in the college admission process, bringing central universities and a spate of other participating institutions onto a shared space. In the past, college admission depended exclusively on the 12th board exam results. This created zones of acute scarcity, built around the abnormally high cut-off marks.

That method, which could favour those with a knack for rote learning, is a thing of the past now. The CUET exam is designed to judge students for their conceptual smarts and capacity for logical thinking. It also allows them the freedom to be judged in subjects of their choice. Students from across India, irrespective of their scores in the 10+2 boards, can thus aspire to find a seat in the college of their dreams, in a course of their choice. To help them tick those crucial boxes in the CUET application, we have brought an innovation this year. A new category has been introduced: best colleges in individual subjects. For the first year, this exercise covers 12 subjects in the arts and science streams.

Students making more informed choices on colleges across India based on their dreams, rather than being hemmed in by what's available within their local horizons, is the logical way to go in times of improved inter-city mobility and communication. It's also a step towards addressing regional disparities. Which brings us to what the rankings tell us. When it comes to the spread of quality higher education, the regional skew is quite strong. Delhi-NCR has 45 colleges in the Top 10. And that's not just a cumulative score. The pattern holds across disciplines—technical education, the pure sciences, arts, commerce, law. By contrast, Bengaluru, the runner-up, has only 14 colleges in the Top 10. All of the top five southern cities put together tot up only 36. Mumbai and Pune combined boast a mere 17. Kolkata has just three. Steered by Executive Editor Kaushik Deka, our Best Colleges Special seeks to uncover these micro-level nuances while casting a drone's eye at the macro picture.

This year, we have a bonus offering for both students and their guardians. We have introduced a brand-new interactive online portal for easy access, analysis and guidance to our Best Colleges of India survey results across 14 major streams and over 2,000 top-ranking colleges. Here, you can look for consistency in excellence by checking the ranks of colleges for the past six years, besides finding out the best colleges in your state as well as city. In addition, you can do cross-comparisons for five major indicators of quality: intake and quality of governance, academic excellence, infrastructure and living experience, personality and leadership development and placement and career. If you want more details of a particular college, you will be guided to individual pages that give you additional information about the courses offered, admission fees, cut-offs, placements, faculty and industry connect. It's truly a goldmine of information and analysis that would enable young minds raring to go to college, to choose well. Please use the link https://bestcolleges.indiatoday.in/ for some happy, productive surfing. We wish aspiring students all the very best.



(Aroon Purie)